

Susana "Annie" Pascual-Guerrero
A visionary leader, a culinary environmentalist

The President of The Cravings Group (TCG) started her successful chain of restaurants 26 years ago when she and her daughter Badjie Guerrero-Trinidad opened a modest bakeshop counter in Katipunan Avenue, Quezon City, Philippines. Good food, great ambiance, excellent service and the desire to continuously satisfy their guests' food cravings were the ingredients to the restaurant's chain of success.

Her desire to share her passion for cooking and to professionalize the culinary industry was her motivation for putting up the Center for Culinary Arts, Manila in 1996. It was her vision and pioneering spirit 18 years ago, when culinary art studies were still an unheard of thing, that has allowed the growth of the profession of culinary arts schools in the Philippines. As President of CCA, Manila, she is fiercely proud of CCA's graduates who now occupy tough jobs in the best hotels here and abroad, or are successful restaurant owners themselves at present.

Her sense of social responsibility and "spirit of giving back to the community" has prompted her to put up the Culinary Education Foundation (CEF), where she is the President. Established in 2001, CEF has leveraged on CCA Manila's success to bring the culinary education to the less privileged members of the society who would otherwise be unable to have access to CCA's top-notch culinary instructors and state of the art facilities. CEF has funded the studies of deserving individuals from the indigent sector of the society including the youth, women, and people with disability. CEF has also brought grassroots culinary and entrepreneurial learning through the "Super Manang Program" and the "Mobile Kitchen Program".

Ms. Guerrero earned her Bachelor of Science degree in Home Economics from the University of the Philippines, Diliman, Quezon City. She was recognized as the first Certified Culinary Professional in the Philippines by the International Association of Culinary Professionals.

In her role as President of TCG, Ms. Guerrero leads the company to its current position as a full service organization with an environmental conscience. She is instrumental in the Company's achievements of receiving numerous awards in ecology, economy, and waste management. She was graciously honored and recognized by the president of the American Culinary Federation, the largest organization of professional chefs and culinarians in the world, with the 2010 Cutting Edge Award for her green advocacy in culinary arts education and restaurant business. Through her inventiveness, and passion to contribute to saving the environment, The Cravings Group, received numerous awards including the Best in Segregation Award and Special Citation for Sustainability from the Zero Basura Olympics, the Grand Master Garbology Award from the QC-Environment Protection and Waste Management Department (QC-EPWMD), Best in Ecology and Economy Award from the Philippine Chamber of Commerce and Industry (PCCI), and Alab ng Puso Award from Earth Day Network, Philippines (EDNP,Inc). She received a UP Commendation from the President of the University of the Philippines Alumni Association, Diliman for her contributions to her alma mater. She was also honored as Mabuhay Gold Awardee (the Oscars of Philippine Hospitality) by the Association of Human Resource Managers (AHRM) in 2006 for her valuable contribution in professionalizing the culinary profession in the Philippine hospitality industry. Continuing to trail blaze her advocacy for environmental change for peace, Ms. Guerrero is championing the Green Chefmanship Program for chefs and culinarians in the food service industry, another significant initiative for mother earth.

A Journey Into A Green Life

The crusade of The Cravings Group (TCG) on environmental transformation in the hospitality industry and the world has taken one step at a time.

Dubbed as culinary environmentalist, its Founder and President. Susana "Annie" Pascual – Guerrero, has shown deep compassion as she cuts across all ages, walks of life and educational background to deliver her message; "We should start caring for the environment and sustainability in all aspects of thinking."; "We have to fill the Earth with love so that it will be renewed and restored. In turn, it will nurture us and revitalize future generations of humanity."

As the author of two groundbreaking green books, An A-Z Guide for a Green Pinoy and An A-Z Guide for a Green Chef, Ms. Guerrero's green advocacies are also emboldened in the practices of all companies under TCG. She takes pride in being requested recently to send the two environmental books as gift to the Holy Father by the implementor of the Bokashi Project of Culinary Education Foundation (CEF), Inc. in partnership with Farm to Table Connections (FTC) in Brgy. Magay, Tanauan, Tacloban, Leyte.

With her efforts, TCG formed strong partnerships with credible organizations to ensure that environmental citizenship is always incorporated as part of TCG's annual strategic plans. These organizations include the Zero Waste Philippines (ZWPH), where she served as President for 4 years, and FTC, an environmental group with an advocacy of spreading the best technology in composting nationwide, the Bokashi Technology. It is noteworthy to add that during Ms. Guerrero's term as President of ZWPH, a non-government organization collaborated closely with the Office of Environmental Ombudsman (OEO) for the strict compliance to Republic Act (RA) 9003, The Ecological Solid Waste Management Act of 2000.

As one of the pillars of TCG, Ms. Guerrero is also personally involved with the Group's corporate social responsibility programs through the Culinary Education Foundation (CEF), whose main advocacies include sustainable and eco-friendly practices and providing livelihood programs and culinary education scholarships.

With passion in her eyes and fervor in her heart, Ms. Guerrero expressed her eco-advocacies by saying: "The pressing challenge of business today is how to sustainably manage waste. The journey towards this endeavor may be an uphill battle against resistance and apathy. But we are determined, relentless and consistent in pursuit of this goal."

Zero Waste and Sustainable Farming

Annie Guerrero accounts as one of her most important sustainability initiatives is promoting zero waste lifestyle, which simply puts fundamental ethical values into action. "It all begins with proper segregation at source. "The country wouldn't be facing such garbage issues had the law on Ecological Solid Waste Management (ESWM) been seriously complied with at the crucial local grassroots levels, like the home and community."

At all TCG establishments, nothing goes to waste, she proudly declares. Waste from the kitchens and offices do not go to the dump. Instead, they are given a new lease in life in different forms and functions. For instance, kitchen waste culled from the restaurants and the schools are gathered for composting and vermiculture. The bokashi compost completes the loop of recycling – from Farm to Fork to Farm concept.

Dry waste, such as bottles, paper and plastic, are segregated and are given a new lease in life as artisan products and upcycled crafts. The Super Manang Program of TCG, a livelihood project involving a group of underprivileged women who were trained to transform recyclable paper into woven handbags, packaging materials, accessories, and other household items and souvenirs that are then sold or as giveaways to guests on many occasions.

The Bokashi fertilizer mainly sustains Anî Farm in Antipolo, which provides some of the vegetable and herb requirements of the Cravings restaurants; and Annie's Haven, a green space found in the heart of Cravings Katipunan and CCA's main campus, which showcased a vertical herb garden. Anî is the new

demo farm of TCG, a new hub of learning in culinary urban gardening and eco-preneurship. It is a powerful tool in ecological and social change.

“Urban organic gardening can be done successfully even on cramped backyard spaces by using plastic discard and containers,” she adds. “By creating your own ‘edible garden,’ you encourage self-reliance and sustainability, with the end of addressing poverty and lessen dependence on relief work for survival.”

Converting Offices into ‘Green’ Spaces

Environmental stewardship and love of God’s creation is the driving force that inspires Ms. Guerrero to elevate TCG into a company with a high consciousness of ecological and social responsibility. In 2010, TCG actively worked towards being a certified ISO 14001 company, the highest global environmental standard – thus, the Environmental Management System (EMS) was revitalized. Through this framework, TCG seriously complied with the guidelines set by the certifying body, TUV Rheinland. It did not take long when in May 2013, TCG was granted the most awaited ISO certification

“We believe that the more information and technologies are shared and exchanged, the faster we move towards becoming both an environmentally and economically sound company,” she says.

Green Chefmanship

Annie Guerrero also initiated the “Green Chefmanship” program to CCA Manila students and all restaurants and production employees mentored by the late Odette Alcantara, a well-respected environmentalist. The course aims to instill the tenets of a “green” kitchen and learn to be actively involved in the conservation of life resources.

“Green chefmanship is 80 percent attitude,” says Ms. Guerrero. “Simple things such as making sure you are using blue flame in cooking, or making the effort to peel and slice carefully helps in reducing volume of waste. In addition, proper preparation and cooking, correct portioning of food that is served translates to least wastage. But even this is not rendered useless, as it is given to hog raisers for feed. By rigorously segregating recyclable bottles and tins and significantly cutting down the use of plastic packaging, residual waste is greatly reduced.”

Also, efforts to turn TCG’s headquarters in Katipunan Avenue (also the main campus of the country’s pioneer culinary school, CCA) into a Green Building have started with the “ozonation” of the whole building. “Ozone has many amazing benefits. It is 2.5 times stronger, 3,000 times faster than chlorine in producing the safest, purest alkaline (at 8 pH) and dissolved oxygen at 9 mg/L drinking water and it is an all-around sanitizing agent,“ she explains. All these aims to make TCG as a hallmark in customized environmental technology.

Deserving Recognition

Annie Guerrero’s team efforts at putting into place TCG’s environmentally sound programs have surpassed expectations, earning its share of awards and recognition locally and internationally from prestigious organizations and institutions. The company has been declared Super Grandmaster Awardee twice in the Zero Basura Olympics. TCG was also conferred the Excellence in Ecology in Economy Award from the Philippine Chamber of Commerce and Industry (PCCI), the Cutting Edge Award from the International Association of Culinary Professionals (IACP), among others.

After a decade of longing for an ISO certification, TCG was finally granted the elusive "Oscar" of Environmental Excellence from SGS of Germany, a global provider of technical, safety, and certification services, making it the only Philippine company to be accorded such honor, as it is now officially the greenest in the food service and hospitality industry.

"This is truly a milestone for our Group, proud and thankful that we have touched the lives of so many employees, students, families even customers. We have also influenced many organizations and reached out to other communities to go Zero Waste," says Ms. Guerrero. "With the certification, we are now more confident to lead by example and promote a lifestyle that protects human health and the environment.”

TCG's most recent international accolade is the Sustainability Business Award (SBA) specifically, its Leadership for Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) in the Community, making TCG the only recipient among top corporations here and abroad.

"The goal of sustainability is simply maximizing and properly using, and maintaining life's resources to remain viable for future generations. It is simple enough to understand that if one puts back what he takes from the environment, then it is replenished and is again available for use.'' reveals Ms. Guerrero.

Despite its roster of awards and recognition, she does not rest on her laurels. "Although recognition and awards encourage and inspire us, it's more of the feeling of joy and fulfillment from our achievements that we have contributed to renewing this country and loving this earth – the only earth that God our Father entrusted to us."

Culinary Education Foundation (CEF)

Since the founding of CEF in Sept 2001, it has evolved into what is now a leading foundation in the hospitality industry. It has earned the respect and support of many partner individuals, company, funding institutions, NGOs who share the same aspiration for which the foundation was created.

CEF has been the beneficiary of many organizations (foreign/local) in the past like World Bank's 'Bagong Paraan' program; CIDA (Canadian International Development Agency) Culinary Training Program, AUSAID of Australia, Mobile Kitchen Project with AI-HU of Taiwan, USDA Grant, DEG of Germany. Local: Nestle's Maggi, Jelly Ace, CDO grant, Department of Tourism (which partnered with CEF) for the past 2years in the Manila Food and Wine Festival, Candon Ilocos Sur who has been supporting scholars for the past 4 years.

CEF also enjoys the support of countless private individuals who sponsors deserving scholars, as well as numerous accomplished Chefs as volunteer Instructors for our Cooking for Life Program (CLP) scholars. CEF takes pride in its achievements and programs, which provided for the welfare of thousands of beneficiaries. To date, there are approximately 4000 beneficiaries under the CEF Program since its founding in 2001.

They all cooked for a CAUSE!



Publications of Susana P. Guerrero

Cookbooks

1. Cravings Cookbook, 1993
2. Cooking with Love, 2001
3. Cooking with Coconut, 2005
4. Easy Guide to Healthy Pinoy Meals, 2007
5. A Pinch of Love, A Cupful of Passion, 2008

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Environmental
1. An A-Z Guide for a Green Pinoy, Student Edition, 2012
2. An A-Z Guide for a Green Chef, 2012

Speaking Engagements

November 24, 2014
Manila Food & Wine Festival
Audience: Distinguished guests & sponsors of the Culinary Education Foundation (CEF), Inc., friends in the hospitality, food & beverage industry

May 15, 2014
Cooking for Life Graduation Ceremony Candon, Ilocos Sur

November 23, 2013
Cooking Demo in Time of Disaster

April 22, 2013
Launching of the Solid Waste Management Compliance Program Ombusdman, QC and signing of Manifesto of Commitment
Audience: Government agencies and civil society organizations

April 12, 2013
Cook For Life Scholarship Program Orientation

March 14, 2013 DENR
Environmental Management Bureau (EMB): National Greening Program, Strategies. Technologies & Opportunities to Reduce Emission in the Philippines.

January 19, 2013
Our Lady Of Pentecost Parish (OLPP): Kalikasan, Kainan at Kalusugan

October 12, 2012
IMF/World Bank Group Annual Meetings:
Tokyo, Japan "Women Business Leaders – Shaping the Future Audience: Women Business Leaders

June 23, 2012
Smokey Mountain Livelihood and ESWM Training

June 8 and 17, 2012
Intramuros Administration (IA) ESWM Eco Tour and Summit Meeting

May 23, 2012
DSM Task Force Berde Launch and Seminar: Waste Mana

March 24, 2012
Navotas "One Day, One Bay"

March 21, 2012
DILG and ZWPH Meeting

March 16, 2012
Resource Person and Guest Speaker at Parañaque PCCI – "Think Green and Go Green"

January 25, 2012
Zero Waste,Philippines entered into a MOA with DILG (Asec Rolando M. Acosta) to advance the vision and mission of ZW, PH for compliance to RA 9003 – The Ecological Solid Waste Management Act.

October 26, 2011
Launched “Ekolohiya Pang-Pinoy” with Zero Waste Philippines / Train the Trainors Workshop

October 7, 2011
PSND Conference: “Entrepreneurship in Food and Nutrition” – The CG3 Experience

August 15, 2011
The 1st Philippine Green Jobs Conference: Job Multipliers in SMX, MOA Natural Resources Protection and Management

August 12, 2011
Green Jobs Conference: Job Multipliers in Natural Resources Protection and Management